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EAUTY AND PERSONAL care products retailer Nykaa and Niramai Health Analytix, which offers early breast cancer screening, are among India's start-up success stories of the past decade.

Founded by Falguni Nayar and Geeta Manjunath, respectively, they paved the way for a generation of woman entrepreneurs in India. Their success broke the myth that start-ups were a male preserve. The days when women were listed as nominal co-founders just to unlock government benefits—although not entirely gone—no longer define the landscape.

As of June 2025, of the 170,000 start-ups in the country, 76,000 were led by women, generating over 1.7 million jobs, according to Dun and Bradstreet. The momentum is building. But is it enough? Not quite. Are we moving forward? Absolutely.

For start-ups led by women, the journey to success is anything but smooth. Building a start-up is hard for anyone—but for women, the climb is often steeper.

Take Suta, the maker of handmade saris, blouses and other apparel, which derives its name from co-founders Sujata and Tanya Biswas. In less than 10 years of inception, the company has engaged 16,000 weavers, built a customer base of 300,000 and logs ₹76 crore in annual revenue. It sells its products online and also runs 18 stores.

Yet, co-founder Sujata Biswas isn't quite rah-rah when talking about the breakthrough achieved by women in the world of start-ups. When a woman wants to set up a business, she is still not taken seriously, she says. The siblings founded Suta in 2016.

"When we started out, entrepreneurship wasn't such a big conversation, nor was there a well-developed ecosystem for founders," says Sujata Biswas, who studied in College of Engineering and Technology, Bhubaneswar, and Indian Institute of Foreign Trade, New Delhi.

"And yes, being women came with its own set of challenges—people assumed they could fool us, or dismissed what we were building as a 'passion project.' It's common: when women start something, it's often seen as something they can do from home, an add-on, a side hustle," she adds.

Why is it tougher for women than men to be taken seriously and attain success in the start-up world? From conversations with several woman founders, one common thread emerged: mindset.

RESILIENCE, HARD WORK, FUNDING

Can women founders thrive only in retail or direct-to-consumer businesses such as Nykaa Fashion and Sugar Cosmetics? That, again, is a mindset issue.

Sonam Motwani of Karkhana.io is a compelling counterexample. Karkhana.io, an on-demand manufacturing platform offering flexible, scalable turnkey solutions across electronics, automotive and aerospace businesses, operates in a sector long dominated by men. Even so, Motwani stepped in—and never stepped back.

"It's definitely easier for a man than for a woman. I had to work much harder to break barriers and build serious relationships with suppliers, or even to pitch what I was trying to create with Karkhana.io. In the initial months, it took far more effort for people to take me seriously, and a lot of that came down to gender," says Motwani.

Fast forward to today from 2018: Karkhana.io is a ₹71

Starting Up

- 1 **76,000 women-led start-ups now power India's ecosystem and have created 1.7 million jobs—yet they form less than half the entrepreneurship base and still have to fight for equal visibility and opportunity**
- 2 **For every ₹100 of VC money, women-led start-ups receive just ₹4. Big-ticket (\$100 Million+) funding has vanished since 2021, making it more difficult for women scaling up beyond Series A**
- 3 **Women are now building in manufacturing, fintech, health-tech and other traditionally male-dominated categories**
- 4 **Mindset shifts, family support and investor openness matter—but without stronger tech and digital literacy (currently prioritised by only 8%), women founders risk hitting a scale ceiling**